

BEYOND THE RED PLANET

Author: Marcus Hale

Genre: Science Fiction

Manuscript Length: 87,000 words

CHAPTER ONE

The Signal

For six months, Captain Elias had listened to silence.

Space was different from what he had imagined as a child.

It wasn't beautiful.

It was enormous.

Empty.

Unforgiving.

The Horizon moved through it like a grain of sand through an ocean.

Mars had disappeared behind them two days ago.

Earth was still thirty-one million kilometers away.

Home.

Elias looked at the photograph attached beside his console.

His daughter was smiling.

She had lost two front teeth when the picture was taken.

He touched the corner of the photograph.

"Almost home."

The radio crackled.

Elias looked up.

Three pulses.

Then silence.

He replayed the recording.

Three pulses.

"Engineering?"

A voice answered.

"Yes, Captain?"

"Did you hear that?"

"Hear what?"

Elias replayed it.

The bridge became quiet.

Then the radio spoke again.

"Are you still there?"

Nobody moved.

Elias leaned toward the receiver.

"This is the exploration vessel Horizon. Identify yourself."

Static.

Then:

"We are what's left."

The signal disappeared.

Elias looked at his crew.

"Trace it."

The navigation officer shook his head.

"I can't."

"Why?"

"Because it isn't coming from outside."

Elias frowned.

"Then where?"

The officer pointed toward the screen.

"It's coming from Earth."

The bridge went silent.

Earth was supposed to be sending no signals.

The mission control network had gone quiet fourteen hours earlier.

Elias stared at the coordinates.

A second message arrived.

DO NOT COME HOME.

Then the ship turned.

Every warning alarm began screaming.

Elias grabbed the controls.

"Who changed our course?"

Nobody answered.

Because nobody had touched them.